

The Incomprehensible Work of Christ at Calvary

Introduction

I have always been profoundly awestruck by what Jesus accomplished at Calvary. While we often focus on His horrific physical suffering—the nails, the thorns, the unimaginable agony—I have long sensed that something even greater, a far deeper anguish, awaited Him there.

A study of Luke 22:39–46 stirred my heart afresh and compelled me to gather these reflections—drawn from Scripture and shaped by the insights of believers who have gone before. This is not an attempt to explain the inexplicable, but a humble offering of truth and wonder meant to illuminate something of the staggering magnitude of His sacrifice.

We will never fully comprehend what Jesus endured on that sacred hill. But we can behold it with awe. We can respond with worship. And we can live changed—because *“It is finished”* was not the end, but the beginning.

Unless otherwise noted, all Scripture quotations in this paper are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB).

1. Gethsemane: The Agony Before the Cross

At the center of our faith stands a hill called Calvary—and on that hill, a cross. And on that cross, the Son of God, willingly offered and fully obedient, giving Himself for our sake.

But before Calvary, there was Gethsemane.

Before the nails, there was the cup.

Before the cry *“It is finished,”* there was a prayer:

“Father, if You are willing, take this cup from Me. Yet not My will, but Yours be done.” — Luke 22:42

This prayer pulls back the veil and gives us a glimpse into the depth of Jesus' anguish as the cross approached.

Jesus came to the Mount of Olives “as usual” (Luke 22:39). Though He knew Judas would find Him there, He made no effort to hide. He did not shrink back from what awaited Him.

Withdrawing from His disciples about a stone's throw, He knelt and prayed. Luke tells us that, being in anguish, He prayed more earnestly, and *“His sweat became like drops of blood falling to the ground”* (Luke 22:44).

Whether Luke intended to describe actual blood or sweat falling like blood, his purpose is unmistakable: Christ was experiencing extraordinary anguish.

He prayed that the cup might pass from Him, yet submitted perfectly to the Father's will.

An angel strengthened Him.

But the cup was not removed.

2. The Cup: A Symbol of Divine Judgment

Why such anguish?

What was contained in this cup?

Throughout the Old Testament, the cup frequently symbolizes God's judgment against sin.

Psalm 75:8 declares:

“For a cup is in the hand of the LORD, full of foaming wine mixed with spices. He pours from His cup, and all the wicked of the earth drink it down to the dregs.”

Isaiah speaks of Jerusalem having drunk:

“the cup of His fury.” — Isaiah 51:17

And through Jeremiah, God commands:

“Take from My hand this cup of the wine of wrath.” — Jeremiah 25:15

The biblical imagery is unmistakable: the cup represents divine judgment.

Jesus knew what awaited Him.

At Calvary He would bear the judgment due to sinners—not as an unwilling victim caught in circumstances beyond His control, but as the willing Lamb of God.

Jesus had already declared:

“I lay down My life so that I may take it up again. No one takes it from Me, but I lay it down of My own accord.” — John 10:17–18

The cross was not an accident of history.

It was the purpose for which the Son had come.

3. The Sinless One Bore Our Sin

Paul writes:

“God made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf, so that in Him we might become the righteousness of God.” — 2 Corinthians 5:21

Here lies one of the incomprehensible mysteries of the cross.

The sinless One bore our sin.

The Beloved Son bore our curse.

The One who had never sinned stood in the place of sinners.

This does not mean that Christ became sinful in His nature. Scripture is emphatic that He was without sin. Rather, He bore our sin judicially and sacrificially as our substitute.

Isaiah had foretold:

“He was pierced for our transgressions, He was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was upon Him, and by His stripes we are healed.... And the LORD has laid upon Him the iniquity of us all.” — Isaiah 53:5–6

At Calvary, Jesus cried:

“My God, My God, why have You forsaken Me?” — Matthew 27:46

Those words, drawn from Psalm 22:1, take us into depths we should approach with reverence.

But at Calvary, something occurred that had never occurred in eternity before.

There was no rupture in the Trinity, for what occurred at Calvary was the will of the Father and the willing obedience of the Son. Scripture does not say that the Father ceased loving the Son or that the divine nature was somehow divided. Rather, the Father gave the Son, and the Son willingly gave Himself for us.

But neither should we weaken Christ's words.

In bearing our sin and judgment, the Son truly experienced the horror expressed in that cry of forsakenness—an experience unlike anything He had known in the eternal fellowship of the Father and the Son.

The physical sufferings of crucifixion were horrific beyond description. Yet the New Testament directs our attention beyond the nails, thorns, mockery, and wounds to something even greater:

He bore our sins.

He endured judgment in our place.

The righteous One suffered for the unrighteous to bring us to God (1 Peter 3:18).

This is the unfathomable agony—and glory—of Calvary.

4. Heaven and Earth Bore Witness

The crucifixion was no ordinary death.

From noon until three in the afternoon, darkness came over the land (Matthew 27:45).

At Jesus' death, the veil of the temple was torn in two from top to bottom. The earth shook, and the rocks were split (Matthew 27:51).

Creation itself bore witness to the extraordinary significance of what was taking place.

We should be careful not to claim knowledge Scripture does not give us about precisely what every angel witnessed or understood at Calvary. Yet Scripture does tell us that the heavenly host takes profound interest in God's work of redemption.

Peter speaks of the gospel as:

“things into which angels long to look.” — 1 Peter 1:12

What God was accomplishing through Christ was part of a redemptive purpose so magnificent that even the angels gaze upon it with wonder.

There, the spotless Lamb willingly submitted Himself to death.

He bore judgment so we might receive mercy.

He was condemned so that those who believe might be justified.

He experienced forsakenness so that those who are in Him might never be forsaken by God.

Countless times, I have asked myself, *Why would the Lord do this for someone like me?*

And for the life of me, I have never found an answer that comes close to satisfying the question.

His love simply defies human comprehension.

Martin Luther is reported to have wrestled intensely with Christ's cry from the cross before exclaiming:

“God forsaking God! No man can understand that.”

Charles Spurgeon, who recounted the incident, wisely added that even such language must be handled cautiously. He regarded Christ's cry as a depth no human being can fully fathom.

Perhaps that is where we must finally stand:

not pretending to comprehend everything that occurred at Calvary,

but bowing before what God has revealed.

5. The Decision in Gethsemane

Jesus drank the cup at Calvary, but in Gethsemane He willingly submitted Himself to drinking it.

“Yet not My will, but Yours be done.” — Luke 22:42

This was not reluctant resignation.

It was perfect obedience.

While His disciples slept, Jesus prayed.

While they succumbed to weakness, He remained obedient to the Father's will.

And when His betrayer arrived, Jesus did not flee.

When the soldiers came, He did not resist.

When Peter drew his sword, Jesus stopped him.

The One who had prayed in anguish now rose to meet those who had come to arrest Him.

He went to Calvary not merely as a victim of human injustice, but as the willing Savior laying down His life.

6. It Is Finished

On the cross, near the moment of His death, Jesus cried:

“It is finished.” — John 19:30

In Greek, John records a single word:

tetelestai (τετέλεσται).

The word comes from *teleō*—to finish, complete, accomplish, or bring something to its intended end.

The significance in John's Gospel is profound. Jesus had spoken repeatedly of completing the work the Father had given Him to do. At Calvary, that work reached its climactic accomplishment. The traditional claim that *tetelestai* itself meant “paid in full” on ordinary receipts should not be pressed; the stronger lexical meaning here is **finished, completed, accomplished**.

Yet the theological truth often expressed by “paid in full” remains gloriously true.

Christ's sacrifice was sufficient.

Hebrews declares that:

“we have been sanctified through the sacrifice of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.” — Hebrews 10:10

And again:

“But when this Priest had offered for all time one sacrifice for sins, He sat down at the right hand of God.... For by a single offering He has made perfect for all time those who are being sanctified.” — Hebrews 10:12, 14

There would be no second Calvary.

No additional sacrifice for sin.

No unfinished portion of the atoning work left for another priest, another offering, or the sinner himself to complete.

Spurgeon expressed the sufficiency of Christ's sacrifice simply:

“It was enough, for Jesus said, ‘It is finished.’”

The mission was accomplished.

The sacrifice had been offered.

The judgment borne.

The way to God opened.

The cry *tetelestai* was not the whimper of a defeated man.

It was the declaration of a completed work.

It is finished.

Conclusion: Let Us Worship, Weep, and Wonder

The finished work of Christ at Calvary is not merely a theological truth. It is our only hope, our greatest treasure, and our eternal song.

Let us never approach the cross casually.

Let us remember Gethsemane—the anguish, the sleeping disciples, and the cup before Him.

Let us remember Calvary—the darkness, the wounds, the cry of forsakenness, and the sinless One bearing our sins.

And let us remember His final declaration:

It is finished.

He drank the cup so that those who are in Him would never drink the cup of divine judgment.

He bore our sin so that we might receive His righteousness.

He was condemned so that we might be justified.

He died so that we might live.

Let us worship—for the sacrifice has been offered once for all.

Let us weep—for the cost exceeds our comprehension.

Let us wonder—for the love displayed at Calvary is unlike any other.

And let us live as those who have been redeemed at immeasurable cost—not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but “*with the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish or spot*” (1 Peter 1:18–19).

We will never exhaust the meaning of Calvary.

We can study it.

We can preach it.

We can sing of it.

We will spend eternity praising the One who accomplished it.

And still we will marvel.

For heaven itself resounds with the song:

“Worthy is the Lamb, who was slain, to receive power and riches and wisdom and strength and honor and glory and blessing!” — Revelation 5:12

The One who said **“It is finished”** is no longer upon the cross.

The tomb is empty.

The Lamb who was slain lives forevermore.

To Him be glory, dominion, and praise—now and forever.

Amen.